

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Medieval History 09 — Vijayanagara & the Bahmani Kingdom (Deccan) — Premium Solved PYQ & Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

09 DECCAN, C. 1336–1565

Vijayanagara • Bahmani • routes, rivers and state formation

A complete learning session: political ecology, competing courts, military adaptation, sources, society, culture, Talikota and transitions.



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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PYQ and practice workbook scope

- **Verified local evidence:** 2024 Q56 exact wording, options and official Series-A key; 2021 Q35 and 2023 Q48 exact wording/options but no locally available official answer keys.
- **Original practice:** 40 broad-coverage MCQs and 12 remedial trap MCQs. Each set independently begins A -> B -> C -> D; original items use historically plausible Deccan distractors and give a correct-versus-closest explanation.
- **Mains:** 8 original examiner-grade answers across 10, 15 and 20 marks, each following claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict.
- **Source boundary:** live UNESCO Hampi content is used only as a bounded material/heritage anchor. No unsupported ASI claim, treaty text, visitor statistic or social census is supplied.

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Practice protocol

For every MCQ, identify the tested discriminator before looking at options: ruler versus ruler, institution versus analogous institution, source claim versus overclaim, or turning point versus instant extinction. For every Mains answer, underline the directive and check whether each paragraph contains named evidence and a qualification. The objective is to make cautious historical reasoning exam-speed retrievable.

Part III — Solved locally routed UPSC Prelims PYQs

PYQ 1 — UPSC Prelims GS-I 2024 Q56: Bhatkal fort

Exact locally preserved question: Who of the following rulers of medieval India gave permission to the Portuguese to build a fort at Bhatkal?

A. Krishnadevaraya B. Narasimha Saluva C. Muhammad Shah III D. Yusuf Adil Shah

OFFICIALLY VERIFIED — local UPSC CSP-2024 Series-A answer key: A. Krishnadevaraya. The local Ans - 2024 - GS1 . txt key records Q56 = A. The historical route is pragmatic cooperation with Portuguese actors in a coast shaped by trade and horse supply. **Provenance qualification:** the precise Bhatkal-fort claim is mainly transmitted through Portuguese testimony; preserve that boundary instead of inventing a grant text, date or fort specification.

Why the alternatives fail: Narasimha Saluva is a real Vijayanagara dynastic name but not the keyed ruler; Muhammad Shah III belongs to Bahmani chronology; Yusuf Adil Shah belongs to the Bijapur successor-state setting. The question is designed to test chronology across related Deccan polities.

PYQ 2 — UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 Q35: women's expertise in Nuniz

Exact locally preserved question: According to Portuguese writer Nuniz, the women in Vijayanagara Empire were expert in which of the following areas?

1. Wrestling
2. Astrology
3. Accounting
4. Soothsaying

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

A. 1, 2 and 3 only B. 1, 3 and 4 only C. 2 and 4 only D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

INFERRED ANSWER — NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Confidence: high. D. 1, 2, 3 and 4. The locally held official question paper is readable, but no official 2021 key is locally available. The local knowledge spine records the same four activities in connection with Portuguese travel writing. Eliminate A, B and C because each omits one activity explicitly included by the question's evidence route.

Source boundary: the basic topic file attributes the list to Domingo Paes whereas the official-paper wording names Nuniz. This package preserves the paper's exact wording and does not pretend the local source conflict has been independently settled. Use the PYQ for option elimination; use "Portuguese accounts" in a Mains answer unless author attribution is separately verified.

PYQ 3 — UPSC Prelims GS-I 2023 Q48: Tungabhadra dam and canal

Exact locally preserved question: Who among the following rulers of Vijayanagara Empire constructed a large dam across Tungabhadra River and a canal-cum-aqueduct several kilometres long from the river to the capital city?

A. Devaraya I B. Mallikarjuna C. Vira Vijaya D. Virupaksha

INFERRED ANSWER — NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Confidence: high. A. Devaraya I. The locally held 2023 paper preserves the exact option order; no official 2023 key is locally held. The repository's source spine associates Deva Raya I with dam/canal works and Deva Raya II with cavalry and archer reorganisation. This makes A the defensible inference; the other rulers are historically plausible Vijayanagara distractors but do not carry this irrigation association in the source base.

Learning route: do not merely memorise A. Build the causal chain: Tungabhadra water work -> cultivation reliability -> revenue/provisioning -> capital capacity. This also separates a hydraulic fact from Deva Raya II's military-adaptation fact.

Original broad-coverage MCQs (40; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation)

Q1. Which combination best identifies the three recurrent strategic zones of Vijayanagara–Bahmani competition?

- A. Tungabhadra doab, Krishna–Godavari basin, and Konkan/Goa coast.
- B. Ganga–Yamuna doab, Kashmir valley, and Bengal delta.
- C. Malwa plateau, Gujarat coast, and Mewar hills.
- D. Kaveri delta, Punjab plain, and Kabul corridor.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct combination follows the local source spine. The closest distractor is the Malwa–Gujarat set because it contains real medieval strategic regions, but not this Deccan triad.

Q2. What is the most methodologically careful use of c. 1336?

- A. Treat it as the exact date of Mahmud Gawan's execution.
- B. Use it as the conventional Vijayanagara foundation anchor while qualifying contested Harihara–Bukka origins.
- C. Use it to prove an unbroken and fully documented founder biography.
- D. Replace all Vijayanagara chronology with an undated legend.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer separates chronology from origin narrative. The closest distractor is the fully documented biography because a foundation tradition is real but not an exhaustive proof.

Q3. Which item is attached most securely to Deva Raya I?

- A. Employment of Muslim cavalymen and archers as the signature reform.
- B. The eight-taraf reform of Bahmani administration.
- C. A Tungabhadra dam and canal works connected to cultivation and revenue.
- D. The execution of Rama Raya at Talikota.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct association is irrigation. The closest distractor is cavalry reform because that belongs to another Deva Raya, Deva Raya II.

Q4. Which statement best describes Deva Raya II's military policy?

- A. He abolished cavalry in favour of temple guards.
- B. He founded the Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.
- C. He created five Deccan Sultanates after 1527.
- D. He adapted to competitive warfare by employing Muslim cavalymen and archers.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer identifies adaptation under military pressure. The closest distractor is cavalry abolition because it deliberately reverses the source's emphasis on mounted capability.

Q5. Why was the Tungabhadra doab politically valuable?

- A. Its fertility and frontier position made it a revenue and strategic zone.
- B. It was solely a Portuguese shipping station.
- C. It contained the Bahmani madrasa at Bidar.
- D. It was outside all Vijayanagara–Bahmani military interaction.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct answer joins agrarian and military value. The closest distractor is the shipping-station claim because coast and port logic is relevant elsewhere, not to the doab.

Q6. What gave the Krishna–Godavari basin a distinctive stake in rivalry?

- A. It was merely a ceremonial capital without cultivation.
- B. It combined fertile land with ports tied to regional foreign trade.
- C. It was the original name for the Bidar madrasa.
- D. It ended the need for imported horses.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer connects agrarian and commercial features. The closest distractor is ceremonial-capital language, plausible for a court city but inaccurate for the basin mechanism.

Q7. Which chain best explains the strategic value of the Konkan coast?

- A. Coastal temples eliminated the need for markets and merchants.
- B. River dams made the coast independent of sea routes.
- C. Ports connected trade and imported horses to the cavalry needs of inland states.
- D. The coast was politically irrelevant until the nineteenth century.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct chain is port -> commerce/horse supply -> military capacity. The closest distractor is river-dam independence because it confuses inland water works with maritime access.

Q8. What does a cautious comparison of amaram and iqta require?

- A. Calling both terms exactly identical because both involved revenue.
- B. Treating amaram as a Bahmani word for eight tarafs.
- C. Describing iqta as a Portuguese fort privilege.
- D. Attention to hereditary nayaka service and the non-transferable local stake of amaram.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer explains why a simple equation fails. The closest distractor is identity-by-revenue because both are fiscal terms but differ in tenure and political context.

Q9. Which is a reasonable inference from hereditary nayaka control of amaram territories?

- A. It could support mobilisation yet create limits on centralisation in crises.
- B. It removed all local military authority from the empire.
- C. It made Vijayanagara a directly ruled Portuguese colony.
- D. It prevented any regional power after 1565.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct inference recognises both service and autonomy. The closest distractor is the removal-of-local-authority claim, the opposite of the hereditary intermediary logic.

Q10. Which traveller is specifically associated in the source base with seven enclosures, bazaars and canals?

- A. Hasan Gangu.
- B. Abdur Razzaq.
- C. Mahmud Gawan.
- D. Firuz Shah Bahmani.

Answer: B

Explanation: Razzaq is used for the urban image of Vijayanagara. The closest distractor is Firuz Shah Bahmani because he is a contemporary Deccan ruler, not a traveller source.

Q11. How should traveller descriptions of wealth be handled?

- A. As proof that every household had identical consumption.
- B. As reasons to ignore archaeology and inscriptions.
- C. As valuable observer evidence to be cross-checked, not as exact statistical surveys.
- D. As official revenue registers issued by the court.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct answer specifies genre and limit. The closest distractor is official-register language because it mistakes a traveller's narrative for an administrative record.

Q12. What is the safest interpretation of Portuguese observations about women's expertise?

- A. They prove all women across the empire held the same occupations.
- B. They prove women were absent from accounting and writing.
- C. They replace the need to identify author and genre.
- D. They indicate visible specialised roles in the observed social world but not universal conditions.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer preserves the evidence and its boundary. The closest distractor is universal-condition language because it overgeneralises a real list.

Q13. Which relation is best supported for Krishnadeva Raya and Portuguese actors?

- A. Generally cooperative relations shaped by west-coast and horse-trade pragmatism.
- B. Complete Portuguese command over Vijayanagara administration.
- C. No contact because inland courts never used ports.
- D. A Bahmani eight-taraf settlement at Bhatkal.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct answer is bounded cooperation. The closest distractor is no-contact language because it ignores the maritime links central to the topic.

Q14. What is the official local status of UPSC Prelims 2024 Q56?

- A. Official Set-A key: option B, Narasimha Saluva.
- B. Official Set-A key: option A, Krishnadevaraya.
- C. Official Set-A key unavailable locally.
- D. A reconstructed question with no preserved options.

Answer: B

Explanation: The local Series-A key gives Q56 = A. The closest distractor is Narasimha Saluva because it is a real Vijayanagara dynastic name listed in the question.

Q15. What was the Bahmani kingdom's foundation date and founder association?

- A. 1336; Harihara and Bukka.
- B. 1463; Mahmud Gawan.
- C. 1347; Hasan Gangu/Alauddin Bahman Shah.
- D. 1565; Rama Raya.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct pairing distinguishes Bahmani formation from Vijayanagara's conventional anchor. The closest distractor is 1336 with Harihara–Bukka because it is the parallel Vijayanagara fact.

Q16. Which capital sequence is correct for the Bahmani kingdom?

- A. Bidar followed by Hampi under Deva Raya I.
- B. Goa followed by Dabhol under Krishnadeva Raya.
- C. Mandu followed by Ahmedabad under Mahmud Gawan.
- D. Gulbarga followed by Bidar under Ahmad Shah.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct sequence is Bahmani. The closest distractor is Mandu–Ahmedabad because both are real regional capitals, but not Bahmani.

Q17. Which office most accurately describes Mahmud Gawan?

- A. Wakil-i-sultanat or Bahmani prime minister.
- B. Hereditary nayaka of the Tungabhadra doab.
- C. Founder of the Sangama dynasty.
- D. Portuguese captain at Goa.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct answer identifies Gawan's central ministerial role. The closest distractor is nayaka because both relate to military-fiscal power but belong to distinct courts.

Q18. What was the administrative number linked to Mahmud Gawan's reform?

- A. Five amaram districts.
- B. Eight tarafs.
- C. Seven traveller enclosures.
- D. Four Portuguese captaincies.

Answer: B

Explanation: The source expressly identifies eight tarafs. The closest distractor is seven enclosures because it is a real Vijayanagara urban number but not an administrative reform.

Q19. What was khalisa in the context of Gawan's programme?

- A. A hereditary nayaka title.
- B. A name for the Tungabhadra canal.
- C. Land or resources reserved for the sultan's direct fiscal base.
- D. A Portuguese warehouse at Bhatkal.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct answer identifies a central fiscal resource. The closest distractor is hereditary nayaka because both concern power over revenue but operate differently.

Q20. Why did Gawan's execution matter analytically?

- A. It immediately created the Sangama dynasty.
- B. It restored Vijayanagara's capital after Talikota.
- C. It ended all horse trade through west-coast ports.
- D. It exposed how factional politics could undo a vulnerable centralising programme.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer links an event to institutional fragility. The closest distractor is a restored-capital claim because it uses a real later crisis but reverses chronology.

Q21. Which pair correctly identifies the main Bahmani elite factions?

- A. Deccanis and Afaqis/gharibs.
- B. Sangamas and Tuluvas.
- C. Sharqis and Lodis.
- D. Mamluks and Cholas.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct pair is the Bahmani factional vocabulary. The closest distractor is Sangamas–Tuluvas because they are real Vijayanagara dynasties.

Q22. What should not be inferred from the terms Deccani and Afaqi?

- A. That office and access to influence could be politically contested.
- B. That each was an unchanging, uniform ethnic bloc with a single permanent interest.
- C. That factional rivalry affected court politics.
- D. That Gawan's enemies could exploit elite divisions.

Answer: B

Explanation: The unsafe inference essentialises political labels. The closest distractor is office competition, which is exactly the historically useful way to interpret factions.

Q23. What did Gawan's coastal expansion towards Goa and Dabhol demonstrate?

- A. That coastal routes mattered only after the Mughal conquest.
- B. That Vijayanagara abandoned all cavalry interests.
- C. That western ports had both commercial and strategic significance.
- D. That Gulbarga was a Portuguese possession.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct answer connects port control to trade and military supply. The closest distractor is cavalry abandonment because it reverses the horse-supply mechanism.

Q24. What is the evidence value of the Mahmud Gawan Madrasa?

- A. It proves every Bahmani subject was a scholar.
- B. It proves Bidar was Vijayanagara's first capital.
- C. It is a source for the exact volume of every tax.
- D. It is material evidence of courtly educational patronage and artistic skill at Bidar.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer is institutionally precise. The closest distractor is universal scholarship, an overclaim from a real learning institution.

Q25. Which five successor states emerged from Bahmani disintegration?

- A. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar.
- B. Hampi, Madurai, Kanchipuram, Thanjavur and Srirangam.
- C. Delhi, Agra, Lahore, Kabul and Ajmer.
- D. Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal, Jaunpur and Kashmir.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct list is the standard Deccan successor set. The closest distractor is the regional-kingdom list, which is medieval but belongs to another topic field.

Q26. Which statement gives the best interpretation of Talikota?

- A. It was a Bahmani victory in 1347 before Vijayanagara formed.
- B. It was a coalition victory that shattered Vijayanagara's capital and great-power phase without instant political extinction.
- C. It was a Portuguese naval battle at Bhatkal.
- D. It permanently united all Deccan states under one dynasty.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer combines consequence with qualification. The closest distractor is permanent union because coalition success did not produce a single lasting unified state.

Q27. Which individual was executed in the coalition context of 1565?

- A. Mahmud Gawan.
- B. Harihara I.
- C. Rama Raya.
- D. Hasan Gangu.

Answer: C

Explanation: Rama Raya is tied to Talikota. The closest distractor is Gawan because he too was executed in a major Deccan political crisis, but in 1482.

Q28. What remained after the 1565 destruction?

- A. No Vijayanagara-connected authority anywhere in the south.
- B. A restored Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.
- C. The immediate Mughal annexation of all southern territories.
- D. Aravidu rule and regional nayaka political capacity in altered form.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer rejects instant extinction. The closest distractor is restored Bahmani rule because both are false return-to-earlier-order narratives.

Q29. Which official live heritage source was used as a bounded current anchor?

- A. UNESCO World Heritage Centre's Group of Monuments at Hampi property page.
- B. An unverified social-media map of medieval battlefields.
- C. A coaching claim about visitor statistics.
- D. A later fictional chronicle.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct source is official and bounded to Hampi's property description. The closest distractor is a coaching claim because it might mention Hampi but lacks authoritative provenance.

Q30. What does the UNESCO Hampi page securely support for this package?

- A. Exact medieval population totals for Hampi.
- B. The integrated survival of fortifications, water structures, royal and sacred complexes, markets and landscape at the capital site.
- C. A full account of every fifteenth-century court office.
- D. An official verdict on the founders' disputed origin story.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer stays within heritage evidence. The closest distractor is office history because important state questions require texts and other sources, not a heritage page alone.

Q31. Why is the phrase "Hindu bulwark" insufficient as a complete analysis of Vijayanagara?

- A. It accurately explains all cavalry recruitment and port politics.
- B. It is a precise label for Mahmud Gawan's reforms.
- C. It obscures contested origin stories, pragmatic recruitment, political geography and regional interaction.
- D. It shows why travel accounts need no criticism.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct answer identifies what the phrase hides. The closest distractor is the all-cavalry-and-port claim because it exposes the problem: the phrase cannot explain those mechanisms.

Q32. What does the 1367 Mudkal/Tungabhadra conflict add to a mature answer?

- A. It marks the formal start of Portuguese rule at Goa.
- B. It proves the final breakup into five Sultanates.
- C. It establishes the Aravidu dynasty after 1565.
- D. It shows recurrent conflict and a reported agreement against slaughter of helpless civilians.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct answer adds a bounded norm to war history. The closest distractor is successor-state breakup because both concern political conflict but are chronologically distinct.

Q33. Which comparison is most defensible?

- A. Vijayanagara military adaptation under Deva Raya II and Bahmani centralising reform under Gawan were different responses to competition.
- B. Both states had identical transferable iqta systems.
- C. Neither court used territorial revenue for military purposes.
- D. Gawan's reform was a Vijayanagara temple programme.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct comparison notes shared pressure and different institutions. The closest distractor is identical-iqta language because it mistakes a broad functional comparison for an institutional identity.

Q34. Which link best explains why markets belong in a political history of Hampi?

- A. Markets had no relation to water or road systems.
- B. Markets connected urban consumption, ritual circulation, merchants and the capital's provisioning.
- C. Markets prove every commodity was imported from Portugal.
- D. Markets were identical to eight Bahmani tarafs.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer treats markets as urban infrastructure. The closest distractor is import-only language because commerce included local and regional production as well as external links.

Q35. What is a valid source-critical reading of a monument?

- A. It is useless because it does not speak.
- B. It supplies a complete census without textual support.
- C. It can reveal patronage, material practice and spatial organisation, but not every resident's belief or welfare.
- D. It settles all disputed dynastic origin narratives.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct answer specifies evidence and limit. The closest distractor is a complete census, an attractive but unsupported extension from material remains.

Q36. Which topic bridge is historically sound?

- A. Talikota made all Deccan courts disappear before Mughal expansion.
- B. The Mughals inherited an unchanging Bahmani bureaucracy directly in 1347.
- C. Deccan politics ended once coastal horses were imported.
- D. Bahmani successor states and changed Vijayanagara/nayaka politics form part of the setting for later Mughal–Deccan contests.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct bridge preserves a competitive field. The closest distractor is direct unchanging inheritance, which ignores fragmentation, adaptation and later change.

Q37. What is the safest conclusion about Krishnadeva Raya's cultural patronage?

- A. It was an instrument of courtly legitimacy alongside campaigns, irrigation and diplomacy.
- B. It made administrative and military institutions irrelevant.
- C. It proves all literary production was identical in language and audience.
- D. It ended the importance of nayakas.

Answer: A

Explanation: The correct answer locates patronage among other state practices. The closest distractor is all-literature-identical language because patronage need not erase regional diversity.

Q38. What does political marriage in the Deccan warn an analyst against?

- A. Concluding that all warfare was fictional.
- B. Assuming that recurrent rivals had no diplomatic or social interactions.
- C. Treating marriage as an eight-taraf reform.
- D. Dating the Bahmani foundation to 1565.

Answer: B

Explanation: The correct answer qualifies a war-only model. The closest distractor is warfare-fiction because interaction and conflict can coexist.

Q39. Which fact most clearly separates a capital shift from a state's origin?

- A. Vijayanagara was founded only when the Aravidu dynasty took power after 1565.
- B. Bidar was the original Portuguese fort at Bhatkal.
- C. The Bahmani kingdom was founded in 1347, while Ahmad Shah later shifted its capital from Gulbarga to Bidar.
- D. Mahmud Gawan shifted Vijayanagara from Hampi to Gulbarga.

Answer: C

Explanation: The correct statement separates state formation from a later capital reorientation. The closest distractor is the Aravidu claim because it uses a real later dynasty but collapses centuries of chronology.

Q40. Which answer best links source criticism to a Prelims option-elimination method?

- A. Replace original options with a generic ruler label to make the question easier.
- B. Treat an unavailable official key as officially confirmed if an online explanation agrees.
- C. Ignore author and genre whenever a traveller's detail is memorable.
- D. Preserve official option order for a verified PYQ, then test each ruler against chronology and evidence provenance.

Answer: D

Explanation: The correct method keeps the official paper intact and distinguishes verified from inferred answers. The closest distractor is the online-explanation shortcut because it may be useful for discovery but cannot substitute for the locally unavailable official key.

Independent answer-rotation audit — Original broad-coverage MCQs (40; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation): A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D A B C D

Remedial trap MCQs (12; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation)

Q1. Identify the unsafe statement about Vijayanagara's foundation.

- A. The conventional 1336 date proves every detail of Harihara and Bukka's origin story.
- B. The foundation narrative contains disputed elements requiring source caution.
- C. A conventional date can remain useful for chronology.
- D. State formation can be studied through later institutions and evidence.

Answer: A

Explanation: The unsafe statement converts a chronological anchor into a complete biography. The closest distractor is the useful-date statement, which is correct but limited.

Q2. Identify the unsafe ruler association.

- A. Deva Raya I is associated with irrigation works.
- B. Deva Raya II is the ruler identified with the Tungabhadra dam and canal-cum-aqueduct.
- C. Deva Raya II is associated with military adaptation.
- D. Mahmud Gawan is associated with eight tarafs.

Answer: B

Explanation: The unsafe statement swaps the two Deva Rayas. The closest distractor is Deva Raya II's military association because it is a real but different fact.

Q3. Identify the unsafe institutional equation.

- A. Amaram involved hereditary nayaka service and territorial revenue.
- B. A comparison must attend to transferability and local political stakes.
- C. Amaram was simply a transferable Sultanate iqta under another name.
- D. Fiscal-military systems can be functionally compared without being identical.

Answer: C

Explanation: The unsafe statement erases the source's explicit caution. The closest distractor is functional comparison because it is allowed only when institutional difference is retained.

Q4. Identify the unsafe Talikota conclusion.

- A. The capital suffered severe destruction after the coalition victory.
- B. The battle ended Vijayanagara's great-power phase.
- C. Aravidu rule persisted in a reduced political setting.
- D. The 1565 battle instantly ended every Aravidu and nayaka political continuity.

Answer: D

Explanation: The unsafe statement is an instant-extinction error. The closest distractor is great-power-phase language because it is strong yet qualified.

Q5. Identify the unsafe reading of a Portuguese account.

- A. A list of women's specialised skills establishes the social condition of all women in the empire.
- B. The list makes visible roles in the observer's field of vision.
- C. Travel writing has genre and access limits.
- D. The question's precise author attribution should be preserved.

Answer: A

Explanation: The unsafe statement turns an observation into a census. The closest distractor is the visible-roles statement, which is the proper narrow inference.

Q6. Identify the unsafe statement about Bhatkal.

- A. The local official Series-A key gives Q56 as A, Krishnadevaraya.
- B. Because the 2024 official key is A, no provenance caution about Portuguese testimony is needed.
- C. The exact fort wording is mainly preserved through Portuguese accounts.
- D. Exam verification and source criticism can be stated together.

Answer: B

Explanation: The unsafe statement falsely opposes examination verification and source analysis. The closest distractor is the official-key statement, correct but not exhaustive.

Q7. Identify the unsafe statement about Bahmani factions.

- A. They are useful labels for contested access to office and influence.
- B. Factional conflict helped make Gawan's reforms vulnerable.
- C. Deccanis and Afaqis were timeless homogeneous peoples whose political interests never changed.
- D. Court coalitions could be politically unstable.

Answer: C

Explanation: The unsafe statement essentialises faction labels. The closest distractor is the office-access reading because it explains their political relevance without reifying them.

Q8. Identify the unsafe statement about architecture.

- A. It provides evidence of patronage and an educational institution.
- B. Material form should be read with patron and urban context.
- C. A monument does not replace social evidence from other sources.
- D. The Bidar madrasa proves that every Bahmani subject received identical education and status.

Answer: D

Explanation: The unsafe statement turns one institution into a social census. The closest distractor is the patronage statement, a secure inference from the building.

Q9. Identify the unsafe statement about coast and cavalry.

- A. Konkan and Goa mattered only after Portuguese conquest and had no earlier horse-trade relevance.
- B. Imported horses made access to west-coast ports strategically valuable.
- C. Ports had commercial and military significance.
- D. Coastal competition connected interior states to external circuits.

Answer: A

Explanation: The unsafe statement deletes the pre-Portuguese horse-port logic. The closest distractor is Portuguese-era relevance, which is true but incomplete.

Q10. Identify the unsafe statement about the Hampi heritage anchor.

- A. The page describes surviving urban, sacred, royal and water structures.
- B. UNESCO's property page supplies exact medieval population and revenue totals for the city.
- C. The page is a bounded heritage source rather than a full political archive.
- D. Traveller accounts and local history sources provide different evidence.

Answer: B

Explanation: The unsafe statement overreads the official heritage page. The closest distractor is the described-surviving-structures statement, which is what the page securely supports.

Q11. Identify the unsafe statement about successor states.

- A. The breakup produced Delhi, Agra, Lahore, Kabul and Ajmer.
- B. Successor courts carried some Deccan political resources into later rivalry.
- C. The Bahmani breakup produced Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar.
- D. Fragmentation did not make the region politically empty.

Answer: C

Explanation: The unsafe statement is the Delhi–Mughal city list, not the Deccan successor set. The closest distractor is later rivalry, a correct consequence of fragmentation.

Q12. Identify the unsafe comparative conclusion.

- A. The two courts competed and interacted in a shared Deccan field.
- B. Revenue zones and horse-port chains shaped strategic choices.
- C. Institutional comparisons require a source-based qualification.
- D. Vijayanagara and Bahmani politics can be fully explained without geography, trade, cavalry or elite institutions.

Answer: D

Explanation: The unsafe conclusion removes the mechanisms that make the comparison historical. The closest distractor is shared-field language, which acknowledges rivalry without an essentialist binary.

Independent answer-rotation audit — Remedial trap MCQs (12; strict A → B → C → D rotation): A B C D A B
C D A B C D

Part IV — Original examiner-grade solved Mains practice

M1. Analyse how political geography, rather than a communal binary, explains the Vijayanagara–Bahmani conflict. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoded: explain a causal mechanism and reject an insufficient frame.

Model solution

Claim. The rivalry was organised around fiscal and strategic geography; religious idioms existed, but do not explain the recurring objects of contest by themselves.

Named evidence -> analysis. The fertile Tungabhadra doab offered revenue and a frontier position. The Krishna–Godavari basin joined cultivation to ports and regional overseas trade. Konkan/Goa mattered because imported horses from Iran and Iraq were crucial for cavalry. These three zones connect land, routes and military supply. Deva Raya II's recruitment of Muslim cavalymen and archers further shows pragmatic learning across political-religious labels.

Qualification and verdict. Geography did not mechanically determine outcomes: dynastic ambition, elite factions, artillery, local alliances and legitimacy claims mattered. Yet the resource-and-route framework explains why wars recurred in particular spaces and why coastal politics affected inland armies. The conflict was therefore a Deccan struggle for capacity, not a simple communal duel.

Why this earns marks: It answers “analyse,” uses four named evidence points, states the limit of the argument and ends with a direct verdict.

M2. Examine Deva Raya I's irrigation works as an instrument of Vijayanagara state capacity. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoded: explain institutional significance, not merely identify a work.

Model solution

Claim. Deva Raya I's Tungabhadra dam and canal works were instruments of state capacity because water control could connect cultivation to revenue and capital provisioning.

Named evidence -> analysis. The local source associates Deva Raya I with a dam across the Tungabhadra and canals; UPSC 2023 Q48 tests the dam-and-canal association. Water diverted towards fields and the capital could improve cultivation reliability, sustain food supply and enlarge the fiscal resources that supported a court and army. The location also matters: Hampi's urban landscape combined river, water structures, markets and defended space, showing that infrastructure formed part of a city-region rather than an isolated engineering project.

Qualification and verdict. A canal does not prove equal benefit for cultivators or automatically explain imperial prosperity; assessment, labour, administration and security remained necessary. Nevertheless, the work shows how ecological management could become a political resource in a competitive Deccan.

Why this earns marks: It uses the named ruler, the material mechanism and a social-evidence qualification rather than treating irrigation as a decorative achievement.

M3. Compare Vijayanagara's amaram–nayaka arrangement with Mahmud Gawan's Bahmani reforms. (15 marks, 200 words)

Demand decoded: compare institutional forms, their shared problem and their different limits.

Model solution

Claim. Both systems addressed fiscal-military mobilisation, but amaram rested on hereditary service intermediaries while Gawan's reforms sought to render territorial nobility more controllable from the centre.

Named evidence -> analysis. In Vijayanagara, amaram assigned territorial revenue to hereditary nayakas for troops and service. This enabled mobilisation through local power, but heredity gave nayakas an independent social base; it should not be equated with transferable iqta. In the Bahmani kingdom, Gawan's eight tarafs, fixed salaries and troop obligations, khalisa resources, land-measurement effort and fort-governor control aimed to limit noble autonomy and protect a central fiscal base. Both show that armies depended on revenue and intermediaries, not only royal command.

Qualification. Neither system was a completed, uniform bureaucracy. Vijayanagara's centre could be strong despite nayaka limits; Gawan's programme depended on fragile court support and his execution in 1482 exposed factional constraints.

Verdict. The comparison reveals two distinct institutional answers to the same Deccan problem—turning land and elite service into military power—rather than two identical “feudal” systems.

Why this earns marks: It has six precise evidence points, makes a true comparison, avoids the amaram–iqta trap and gives a qualified conclusion.

M4. Discuss Krishnadeva Raya's statecraft through the relationship between warfare, culture, water and maritime diplomacy. (15 marks, 200 words)

Demand decoded: integrate four dimensions without turning them into an achievement list.

Model solution

Claim. Krishnadeva Raya's reign was a high point of imperial assertion because campaigns, provisioning, patronage and coastal diplomacy reinforced one another.

Named evidence -> analysis. The Tuluva ruler, dated 1509–29 in the repository chronology, restored internal order and defeated rivals, demonstrating military reassertion. The source also associates his reign with tanks and towns: water works and urban investment could support cultivation, provisioning and durable authority. Literary patronage and architectural activity, including the Hampi/Raya Gopura association on the UNESCO page, made sovereignty visible in courtly and sacred landscapes. Portuguese relations were broadly cooperative; the 2024 Bhatkal PYQ's official answer is Krishnadevaraya, while the exact fort wording must be attributed cautiously to Portuguese testimony. This coastal engagement is intelligible because port access and imported horses affected Deccan strategy.

Qualification and verdict. Courtly cultural evidence does not prove universal prosperity, and campaign success did not erase nayaka or factional constraints. Still, the combination of force, infrastructure, legitimacy and diplomacy explains why the reign is more than a list of victories.

Why this earns marks: It obeys the multidimensional demand, names evidence in each dimension and handles the Bhatkal source boundary accurately.

M5. Evaluate foreign travellers as sources for Vijayanagara's urban and social history. (15 marks, 200 words)

Demand decoded: assess utility and limitation with named observers and types of claim.

Model solution

Claim. Travellers are indispensable for the texture of Vijayanagara's city and courtly life, but their observations require genre-aware cross-checking with material evidence and local sources.

Named evidence -> analysis. Abdur Razzaq's image of seven enclosures, bazaars, canals and wealth helps reconstruct an urban system rather than a palace alone. Nicolo Conti adds to the perception of scale and prosperity. Paes, Barbosa and Nuniz help pose questions about markets, court culture and social visibility. The 2021 Nuniz PYQ's list of women's expertise—wrestling, astrology, accounting and soothsaying—can indicate specialised roles in an observed elite or urban milieu. UNESCO's Hampi description of forts, royal and sacred complexes, bazaars, water structures and suburban settlements provides a material cross-check for an integrated capital landscape.

Qualification. A traveller may exaggerate, misunderstand terms, privilege spectacular spaces or lack access to ordinary households. The women list is not a social census, and "wealth" is not an exact revenue estimate. The repository also preserves an author-attribution discrepancy, so it must not be concealed.

Verdict. Used comparatively and with limits, travellers turn Hampi from a monument list into a social-urban question; used alone, they invite overclaim.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates evidence rather than merely quoting it, names multiple sources and turns each limitation into a method point.

M6. Assess Mahmud Gawan as a centraliser whose reforms were constrained by factional politics. (20 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoded: give a balanced judgement on reform, institutional mechanism and political failure.

Model solution

Claim. Mahmud Gawan was a major centralising statesman because he tried to align territory, revenue, nobles and forts with the sultanate; his fate shows that reform without a stable elite coalition remains fragile.

Named evidence -> analysis. As wakil-i-sultanat from 1463 to 1482, Gawan expanded Bahmani influence towards Goa and Dabhol, connecting frontier policy with trade and horse circuits. His division into eight tarafs sought clearer provincial organisation. Fixed salaries and troop obligations aimed to prevent commanders from treating state resources as private entitlement. Khalisa land reserved a fiscal base for the sultan; land-measurement effort and tighter fort-governor control further targeted provincial autonomy. The three-storeyed madrasa at Bidar, with its scholarly function and coloured tiles, illustrates a court that combined administration, expansion and cultural patronage.

Qualification. Centralisation was neither complete nor socially neutral. It depended on cooperation from competing Deccani and Afaqi/gharib elite networks. These labels should be read as factional-political categories, not permanent ethnic blocs. Gawan's execution in 1482, amid factional hostility, removed a reforming minister and accelerated disintegration, but no single event alone explains the later successor states.

Verdict. Gawan's achievement was to make central control more imaginable and administratively practicable; his failure was structural as much as personal. The subsequent Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar formation demonstrates the cost of an unresolved coalition problem.

Why this earns marks: It gives seven named evidence units, explains how each reform worked, rejects essentialism and reaches a calibrated evaluation.

M7. "Talikota was a transformation of the Vijayanagara political order, not a simple end-date." Discuss. (20 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoded: assess a turning point, preserve destruction and demonstrate continuity.

Model solution

Claim. Talikota/Rakshasa-Tangadi/Bannihatti in 1565 was catastrophic because it destroyed the capital's great-power infrastructure, but it did not erase every dynasty, regional network or service polity associated with Vijayanagara.

Named evidence -> analysis. A coalition of Deccan Sultanates defeated Vijayanagara and Rama Raya was executed. The capital was looted; UNESCO's Hampi property page records massive destruction of its physical fabric after the battle. This mattered because Hampi was not merely a royal residence: its enclosures, markets, sacred complexes, water works and landscape coordination concentrated defence, provisioning and legitimacy. The loss therefore weakened imperial capacity far beyond a battle casualty count.

Continuity and qualification. The Aravidu dynasty persisted with reduced territory, and nayaka formations retained or expanded regional importance. This shows that capital destruction is not the same as social or political disappearance. Conversely, persistence must not minimise the rupture: the great urban centre and imperial balance were profoundly altered. Rama Raya's diplomatic balancing and the coalition context are explanatory factors, but they should not be made a single-cause story.

Verdict. Talikota marks the end of Vijayanagara's metropolitan and great-power phase, while opening a reconfigured southern political landscape. It is best written as a transformation in the relationship between centre, regions and successor powers.

Why this earns marks: It directly tests the quotation, supplies material, dynastic and regional evidence, and avoids both instant-extinction and minimisation traps.

M8. Compare the political legacies of Vijayanagara and the Bahmani kingdom for later Deccan history. (20 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoded: compare selective legacies and connect them to a later field without retrojection.

Model solution

Claim. Vijayanagara and the Bahmani kingdom left distinct but intersecting legacies: both developed fiscal-military responses to Deccan geography, and their fragmentation produced the competitive environment of later Sultanate and Mughal-Deccan politics.

Named evidence -> analysis. Vijayanagara's Hampi centre coordinated water, markets, sacred authority and defence; Deva Raya I's irrigation and Deva Raya II's cavalry adaptation show environmental and military responses. The amaram-nayaka arrangement converted territorial revenue into service while leaving enduring local power.

Bahmani statecraft under Gawan attempted a different route: eight tarafs, khalisa, fixed obligations and fort control sought to make provincial authority more centralised. Its coastal interest in Goa and Dabhol reflects the shared importance of trade and horses. Bahmani factional conflict and Gawan's execution contributed to the emergence of Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar. Vijayanagara's Talikota defeat shattered Hampi's great-power role, yet Aravidu and nayaka continuity remained.

Qualification. Later states did not mechanically inherit a uniform earlier system. Institutions, alliances and territorial scales changed, and Mughal policies should not be projected backward. What persisted were strategic problems—ports, cavalry, fortified routes, elite service and regional legitimacy.

Verdict. The enduring legacy was a plural Deccan political field: successor Sultanates, regional nayaka power and residual imperial claims shaped the terrain that later Mughal expansion had to negotiate, confront and incorporate.

Why this earns marks: It compares, supplies eight named examples, maintains chronology and produces a forward-looking but non-teleological conclusion.

Workbook final retrieval sheet

- **2024 official:** Bhatkal fort -> A Krishnadevaraya.
- **2021 inferred, not officially verified:** Nuniz women-expertise set -> D, all four listed fields.
- **2023 inferred, not officially verified:** Tungabhadra dam/canal -> A Devaraya I.
- **Institution pair:** amaram/nayaka ≠ iqta; eight tarafs/khalisa/salaries = Gawan's centralising programme.
- **Turning-point formula:** Talikota devastated Hampi and ended great-power status; Aravidu/nayaka continuity prevents instant-extinction language.
- **Mains final check:** no unqualified foundation legend, no traveller-as-census claim, no monument-as-society claim, no Portuguese treaty detail without a source.